Change Management Policy

POL-COMP-006 · Version 1.4 · Effective 2025-05-01

1. Purpose

The purpose of this Change Management Policy (POL-COMP-006) is to establish a formal process for managing changes to Acme Corp's systems, including the API Gateway, Payment Gateway, Billing Service, and Kafka Cluster. This policy aims to minimize the risk of disruption to services, ensure compliance with regulatory requirements, and maintain the integrity of the operational environment.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all changes made to Acme Corp's systems that may affect the production environment. It encompasses changes initiated by any role within the organization and includes standard, normal, and emergency changes. The policy is relevant to all technical personnel involved in the design, development, testing, deployment, and maintenance of the specified systems.

3. Policy Statements

3.1 Change Classification

Changes to systems are classified into three categories:

- **Standard Changes:** These are low-risk changes that follow a pre-approved process and do not require additional approval.
- **Normal Changes:** These changes require a formal approval process, including review by the Change Advisory Board (CAB) before implementation.
- **Emergency Changes:** These are changes required to address an urgent issue that could impact service availability or security. These changes are implemented immediately and are reviewed retrospectively within 2 business days.

3.2 Change Advisory Board (CAB)

Normal changes to tier-1 systems, including the API Gateway, Payment Gateway, Billing Service, and Kafka Cluster, require prior approval from the Change Advisory Board (CAB). The CAB is responsible for evaluating the potential impact and risk associated with the proposed changes.

3.3 Rollback Plan

Every change must include a tested rollback plan. This plan must outline the steps required to revert the system to its previous state in case the change fails or causes unforeseen issues.

The rollback plan must be documented and reviewed as part of the change request.

3.4 Change Freeze Period

A change freeze applies during the last two weeks of December. No changes, except for emergency changes, may be implemented during this period to ensure system stability during peak business operations.

3.5 Emergency Change Review

Emergency changes must be documented and reviewed retrospectively within 2 business days of implementation. This review will assess whether the change achieved its intended outcome and identify any issues that arose during the implementation.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Change Initiator:** Responsible for submitting a change request, including all necessary documentation and the rollback plan.
- **Change Advisory Board (CAB):** Responsible for reviewing and approving normal changes and ensuring that all changes align with business objectives and risk management practices.
- **On-call Engineer:** Responsible for implementing approved changes and executing the rollback plan if necessary.
- **Incident Commander:** Responsible for overseeing the implementation of emergency changes and ensuring that retrospective reviews are conducted.

5. Exceptions

Any exceptions to this policy must be documented and approved by the Change Advisory Board (CAB). Exceptions may be granted in extraordinary circumstances, provided they do not compromise the integrity or security of Acme Corp's systems.

6. Enforcement

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. Failure to adhere to the Change Management Policy may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment. Regular audits will be conducted to ensure compliance with this policy.

7. Related Documents

This policy is supported by the following documents:

- **POL-COMP-001: Data Retention Policy:** Establishes guidelines for retaining and managing data.
- **POL-COMP-002: Acceptable Use Policy:** Outlines acceptable behaviors and practices for using Acme Corp's systems.

- **POL-COMP-003: Incident Response Policy:** Defines the process for responding to incidents that may affect system integrity.
- **POL-COMP-004: Access Control Policy:** Describes the access control measures in place to protect sensitive data and systems.

In addition, operational procedures related to the systems mentioned can be found in the relevant runbooks and guides, such as:

- **MAN-ENG-001: Payment Gateway Runbook**
- **MAN-ENG-003: Kafka Operations Guide**
- **MAN-ENG-006: API Gateway Configuration Guide**
- **SOP-OPS-011: Production Deployment and Rollback**

This policy will be reviewed annually to ensure its effectiveness and relevance in the changing operational environment of Acme Corp.